

Health food stores' recommendations for nausea and migraines during pregnancy.

BACKGROUND: Many pregnant women use dietary supplements during pregnancy; however, relatively scant information is available on the safety of these products. Consumers of dietary supplements often rely on employees of health food stores to provide recommendations. **OBJECTIVE:** To evaluate recommendations made by health food store employees in the Phoenix metropolitan area regarding treatment of nausea/vomiting and migraines during pregnancy. **METHODS:** Phone calls were made by a disguised shopper to 155 health food stores in the greater Phoenix area. The caller posed as a woman 8 weeks' pregnant asking for recommendations for treatment of nausea/vomiting and migraines. Responses and recommendations were recorded and then compared with current scientific evidence obtained during a search of the literature using MEDLINE (1966-September 2004) as to whether or not the supplements and the methods of their use during pregnancy were contraindicated. **RESULTS:** Eighty-nine percent of stores offered recommendations for nausea/vomiting, and 82% provided recommendations for migraines. The use of ginger was the most recommended therapy for nausea/vomiting. Only 3.6% of respondents recommended correct usage, but failed to supply the correct dosage and duration. A total of 15 of 278 (5%) recommendations, for both nausea/vomiting and migraines, were for products contraindicated in pregnancy. **CONCLUSIONS:** In light of the increased use of dietary supplements by women during pregnancy, the willingness of personnel in health food stores to make any recommendations should foster concerns by patients and healthcare providers alike. Use of dietary supplements contraindicated in pregnancy could cause significant harm to the mother and/or fetus. Studies are needed to address the need for more stringent guidelines regarding health food stores and their recommendations.